

TENDULKAR ON HIS MATES

“If I could take a quality from their games, it would be Dravid’s patience, Sourav’s ability to calculate and pick and choose in an innings and Laxman’s wrist-work.”

NATURAL ALLY:
Laxman and Dravid
have often created
history



GANGULY ON THE STREAK

“There’s a lot of ability in our group—you’re talking tens of thousands of international runs. But mostly, at that time we played freely. There was no pressure on us.”

and effectiveness.” In his mind there is no argument, “When they were at the top of their game two-three years ago, they were the greatest middle order India has ever had.”

They all know what time he is talking about. Between 2000 and the end of the 2004 season, when India played 41 Tests and won 16, exactly half of those away from home. There were Test wins in the West Indies after 26 years (series lost), in England after 16 years (series drawn), in Australia after 21 (series drawn) and for the first time ever in Pakistan, where after many no-shows, India kept its date with destiny, winning a series away from home. In that time, between them, Dravid,

Tendulkar, Ganguly and Laxman scored 12,367 runs, 32 centuries (11 each to Tendulkar and Dravid), and shared 27 century partnerships.

Why did it happen then, that hot streak when the phrase “best batting line-up in the world” meant what it said. When it was applied to Indian batsmen without the mockery loaded on? “It’s hard to give a reason,” says a smiling Tendulkar shaking his head, “but you’re talking about a lot of quality there.” Laxman includes runs from the top order like Virender Sehwag and his partnership with Akash Chopra in Australia, and believes, “it was a great team, everyone was gelling. It was amazing, we were all in

great nick, getting runs for ourselves and the team.” Dravid’s dissection is more precise, “It coincided with the fact that we raised our games. We are the same age, we had similar experience, we peaked at around the same time.” Ability and freedom, says Ganguly, “we played freely, there was no pressure on the four of us.” Down a phone line from Christchurch, their coach at that time, John Wright, offers an odd-ball explanation, “They batted in a functional way,” he says.

Throughout their history, Indians have never been functional cavalrymen. Swashbuckling yes, suicidal, very often, but functional? Like household gadgets? Wright explains. “They set some very clear goals—batting five sessions, batting in partnerships. Batting was our strength, if we could bat five sessions, put on runs, we knew we could control games.” So, these batsmen knew exactly what was expected of them? “No,” says Wright, “they knew exactly what was needed of them.”

India was able to dominate in opposition territory, says Srinath on the back of this clutch of batsmen operating together. “I just wish,” he says with something sounding like longing, “these four guys had been in alignment for longer.”

They are together again in England and what they will do will not be governed by the motion of the stars, but by their hunger and drive. If there was a single common chord in these diverse players, it lay in their intent to be the master of their destinies. Just like they orchestrated the perfect storm, maybe they can work out how to script the perfect finale. Despite the fact that Indian cricket doesn’t do fond farewells, only bitter and angry ones. If they could pull that off, it would perhaps be their ultimate victory. But the hours before contest commences in England are not for the anticipation of brute reality but for dreaming. They

provide the perfect pause. To acknowledge these remarkable batsmen. To will them to suddenly perform in full-blooded chorus again.

To say thank you for the music. ■

THE LAST GREAT SURGE 1976 - 1980					
BATSMEN	PLAYED	RUNS	AVG	100S	
SUNIL GAVASKAR	39	3851	59.24	15	100 STANDS 17
G.R. VISWANATH	39	2821	47.01	7	HOME WINS 8
DILIP VENGSAKAR	31	1915	43.52	5	AWAY WINS 2
MOHINDER AMARNATH	18	994	34.24	2	